

02 Text and Headings (Typography)

Heading hierarchy · Paragraphs · Semantic text tags · Entities

Headings: h1 to h6

- `h1` carries the highest importance and `h6` the lowest. These tags exist for **importance and outline**, not for font size.
- A page should ideally have **one main `h1`** that states the primary topic of the page.
- **Never skip levels.** Jumping from `h1` straight to `h3` breaks the document outline, which screen reader users rely on to navigate the page.
- If smaller text is required, do not drop to `h4`. Use the correct level and reduce the size with CSS.

Paragraphs and breaks

```
<p>This is a paragraph.</p>
<p>Address line 1<br>Address line 2</p>
<hr> <!-- thematic break: the topic changes here -->
```

- `<br>` should be used only where the line break is genuinely part of the content, such as an address, a poem or song lyrics. Using `<br><br>` for spacing is incorrect; that is what the CSS `margin` property is for.
- A `<div>` or another `<p>` cannot be nested inside a `<p>`. The browser closes the paragraph automatically and the layout breaks.

Semantic text elements

Tag	Meaning and usage
<code></code>	Strong importance, urgency or seriousness. Screen readers may convey it with emphasis.
<code></code>	Visually bold only, with no added meaning, such as a product name in running text.
<code></code>	Stress emphasis that changes how the sentence is read. Rendered in italics.
<code><i></code>	An alternate voice: a technical term, a foreign phrase or a thought. Italic, but no emphasis.
<code><mark></code>	Text highlighted for relevance, such as a matched search term.
<code><small></code>	Side comments, fine print and copyright notices.
<code><sub></code> and <code><sup></code>	Subscript and superscript, used in formulae and footnote markers.
<code><abbr title="..."></code>	An abbreviation whose expansion appears on hover.
<code><blockquote></code> , <code><q></code>	A long block quotation and a short inline quotation respectively.
<code><code></code> , <code><pre></code>	Code fragments. <code><pre></code> preserves whitespace and line breaks exactly as written.
<code></code> , <code><ins></code>	Removed and newly added content, such as a struck-through old price.

RULE OF THUMB

If you only want a visual effect, use CSS (`font-weight` , `font-style`). Choose a tag only when the meaning of the content actually matches it. The difference between `strong` and `b` is not visual; it lies in meaning and accessibility.

HTML entities

A few characters are reserved by HTML and must be written as entities.

Character	Entity	Character	Entity
<	<code>&lt;</code>	>	<code>&gt;</code>
&	<code>&amp;</code>	non-breaking space	<code>&nbsp;</code>
"	<code>&quot;</code>	©	<code>&copy;</code>

A normal space collapses when repeated, whereas ` ` does not. This is why ` ` is sometimes used to keep two words on the same line, though it should not be used to create general spacing.

COMMON MISTAKES

Choosing a heading level for its size · creating spacing with `<br>` · using `<b>` for every bold requirement · forgetting to escape `<` when displaying code, so the browser treats it as a tag.

QUICK RECAP

- Headings define the outline of the document; levels must descend in order.
- Semantic tags carry meaning, presentational tags do not.
- `<pre>` is the only text element that preserves whitespace as written.